

Media Representation of Child Education and Protection in Indian Mainstream Media (Nov 2024 – May 2025)

Report by Dhwani Porwal

1. Executive Summary

This report examines how mainstream Indian media covered child education and protection between November 2024 and May 2025. Articles were sourced from The Indian Express, The Times of India, NDTV, and The Economic Times. Dominant trends in framing, tone, voice, and narrative gaps were revealed through the pattern of data-heavy yet emotionally distant coverage. Children, the subjects of these stories, were rarely given space to speak for themselves. The focus, instead, remained on institutions, statistics, and top-down perspectives.

This lack of narrative intimacy has real implications. When media merely highlights problems without depth or human voice, it risks dulling public engagement and lacks accountability. While a few articles showed promise, especially those that explored solutions or progress, the overall media landscape calls for more empathetic, community-rooted storytelling.

2. Key Trends and Patterns

A. Framing of Children

Children were mostly portrayed as passive figures like dropouts, victims, or data points. Stories about child marriage, labour, and abuse often featured institutional commentary or policy critiques but excluded those children's lived realities. No article quoted a child directly. This silence flattens complexity and reinforces the idea that children are subjects to be spoken about, not with.

“Over 11.70 lakh children are out of school, with the highest numbers in Uttar Pradesh,” reported The Economic Times. Yet no child was asked why.

This absence of voice isn't just a storytelling flaw. It's a structural defect that reflects a media ecosystem that still views children as vulnerable, not visible.

B. Dominant Voices and Sources

Government press statements, court rulings, and institutional reports formed the backbone of most articles. While this lends credibility and structure, it also limits texture.

- The ASER 2024 survey became a frequent anchor point.
- UNESCO’s Global Education Monitoring Report offered global context.
- The Lancet’s early childhood series introduced health-based framing.

However, there was little to no input from teachers, caregivers, children, or NGOs working at the grassroots level. Without such voices, the stories lack personal context and risk presenting policies as one-size-fits-all solutions.

C. Problem vs. Solution Orientation

The majority of the articles flagged systemic failures: falling enrollment, nutritional gaps, legal underreporting, or insufficient safety mechanisms. Yet only a few moved beyond the problem.

“ASER 2024 shows significant improvement in foundational skills,” wrote Indian Express.

It was one of the few articles to explore what’s working and that matters. Consistently focusing on what’s broken can exhaust public empathy, whereas highlighting interventions, local innovations, and recoveries can inspire action.

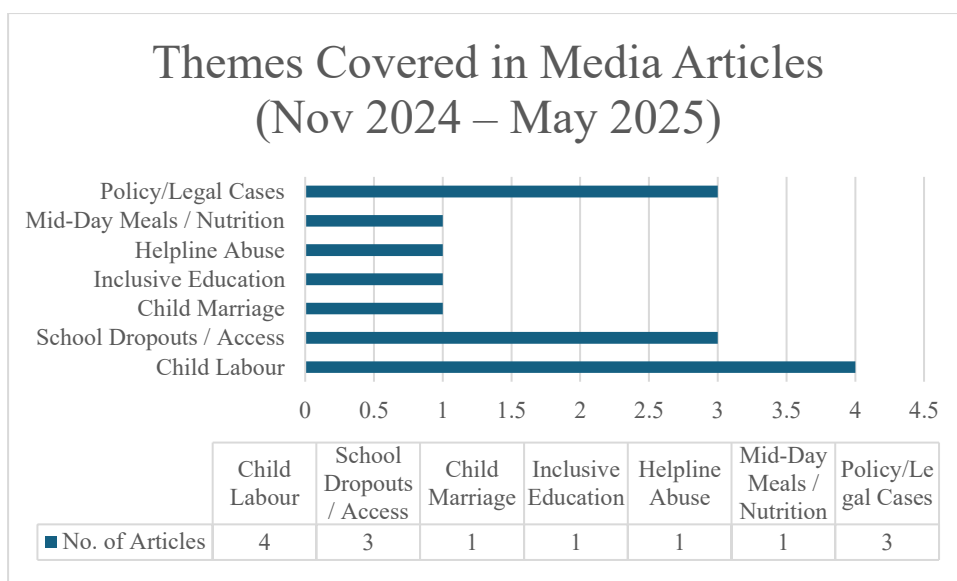
D. Reporting Style and Depth

Most pieces were short, summary-style reports that were quick to inform but slow to engage. Long-form or field-reported narratives were rare.

- NDTV’s reports stood out for their multimedia use, including video stories and visual essays.
- Indian Express offered data-rich insights, though often still source-heavy.

There was a noticeable lack of narrative storytelling, first-person accounts, or photojournalism-led features—elements that could have brought more empathy and visibility to children’s lived conditions.

3. Observations from Select Articles



- **“4 in 10 countries have no food standards in schools, says UNESCO”** (Indian Express, Apr 22, 2025): Offered valuable global framing but lacked an Indian student or meal-worker’s voice to anchor relevance.
- **“ASER 2024: Reading, math skills improve in schools across states”** (Indian Express, Jan 29, 2025): One of the few hopeful narratives. Cited hard data like “Grade 3 children who can read Grade 2 texts rose from 20% to 32%.”
- **“Half the calls on child helpline relate to abuse or counselling”** (TOI, Apr 9, 2025): Powerful figures from RTI; missed opportunity to include survivor voices or child helpline volunteers.
- **“New study based on court data differs from NCRB, more child labour cases in six states”** (Indian Express, Mar 29, 2025): Offered institutional depth, exposing systemic blind spots.

4. Recommendations

1. Quote Children, Not Just Stats

Journalism that discusses child rights without quoting children reinforces adult-centred narratives. Children’s voices must be represented, particularly when the topic affects them directly.

2. Balance Crisis With Change

Highlighting reforms, interventions, and resilience can energize public attention and showcase possibilities. A mix of criticism and constructive insight is essential.

3. Platform Community Stakeholders

Teachers, social workers, parents, and local NGOs offer crucial, grounded context. Their absence from coverage flattens the complexity of issues.

4. Go Beyond Urban Areas

Most coverage was urban and policy-centric. Rural schools, tribal districts, and low-literacy belts need more representation to build a complete national picture.

5. Use Multimedia Better

Photo essays, short videos, and recorded quotes can capture emotions and agency better than text alone, especially for young subjects.

5. Conclusion

Indian media reports on children with data, but rarely with depth. The structural issues are visible (school dropouts, exploitation, missing safety nets) but stories seldom move beyond that. This disconnect between fact and feeling limits the potential for change.

As a journalism student, this project made me reconsider what it means to report *on* childhood versus reporting *with* children. Representation isn't just about who speaks, it is also about who's missing. For media to truly support children's rights, it must reimagine its sources, structures, and responsibilities. Thus, by engaging communities, amplifying children, and capturing nuance, journalists can shift the current lacking narrative.

*“Children are not a story to be told for them –
they are the voices we haven't heard enough.”*